

In Westfield, the numbers no longer make sense

Politicians, activists dig in against more data centers

By Hiawatha Bray
GLOBE STAFF

WESTFIELD — In 2021, government officials in this Western Massachusetts city saw nothing to fear and plenty to like in a plan to build a \$4 billion data center here. The City Council even provided millions of dollars in property tax breaks. It was approved 9-3, and few voters seemed to care.

But that was before the outbreak of the wars over data centers, perhaps the biggest public backlash against Big Tech the United States has seen. Activists throughout the nation warn these giant buildings, crammed with computers, could drain local water supplies, cause a spike in electric rates, and foul the air with exhaust from backup generators.

Now, five years later, simmering opposition from residents has led local officials to a radical change of heart.

Last week, just five years after approving the project from Servistar Realities, the Westfield City Council voted unanimously for a one-year moratorium on additional data centers. Though this won't prevent the already approved Servistar project from going forward, some opponents hope it's the first step to getting its approvals overturned.

"I will tie myself to a bulldozer if I have to," said former city councilor Mary Ann Babinski, 83, "if they get ready to put a shovel into the ground."

DATA, Page A7

Strike shows free transit troubles

As popularity of buses rises, so does the cost

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

LAWRENCE — Three years after eliminating its bus fares, Merrimack Valley Transit was in celebration mode. Ridership had exploded. Rebranded buses were darting through Lawrence at record intervals. And its leaders in October happily hoisted a flame-shaped national award for being named "Agency of the Year."

"Like it was the Stanley Cup," transit system administrator Noah Berger said.

Then, the grand experiment in fare-free transit hit a pothole this summer.

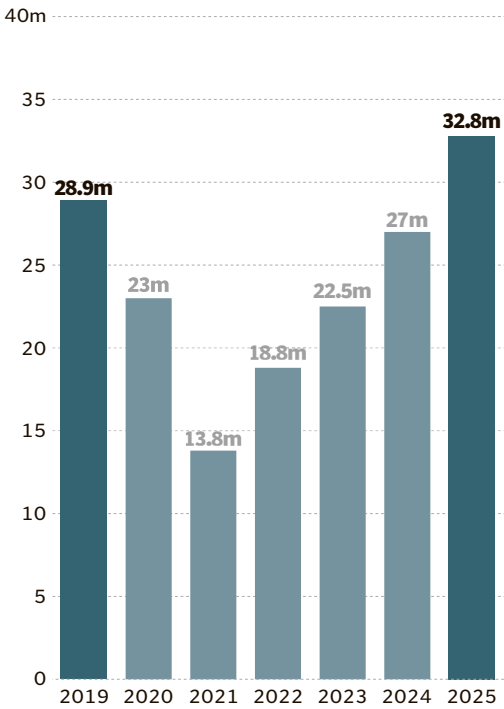
Drivers and mechanics went on strike for 10 days over a fiery dispute about weekend work, itself fueled by systemwide concerns about budgeting for growing rider demand. Thousands of people — most of them poor and car-less — suddenly found themselves without a ride to work or the local Walmart. Almost 30 routes were without bus service.

The strike ended Friday with a temporary agreement, but it exposed both the successes

FARES, Page A10

Growing ridership

Individual passenger trips on regional transit authorities surpassed pre-pandemic levels in fiscal year 2025.



A searing search for answers

'There's just no question: They have been continuing these detentions, stops, pickups.'

REPRESENTATIVE CHELLIE PINGREE, on the recent activities of Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents in Maine

After shooting, Collins's role as GOP intermediary faces scrutiny

By Sam Brodey and Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

In January, just days into the Trump administration's controversial deportation crackdown in Maine, Republican Senator Susan Collins announced the "enhanced operation" was over and implied heavily it had come at her urging.

The move was characteristic of Collins's approach in the Trump era to demonstrate her distinct value by positioning herself as an effective backchannel to a Republican administration for a state led by Democrats.

But the killing of 26-year old Jo-

han Sebastián Durán Guerrero by Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents on the streets of Biddeford, Maine, on Monday underscored what local officials and advocates have known for months: Far from retreating, the agency continued a high level of operations in the state, just more quietly and with different tactics.

The pace and volume of arrests did drop significantly after the conclusion of ICE's heightened operation in January, which resulted in more than 200 arrests over four days, as the Globe previously reported. There were 40 detentions in the

six weeks that followed, according to the Portland Press Herald. (The administration has not yet released its most recent quarterly immigration enforcement data.)

In her statement in January, Collins did not claim ICE would depart entirely from Maine, saying only there were "currently no ongoing or planned large-scale ICE operations here" and the agency "will continue their normal operations that have been ongoing here for many years."

Many local leaders, however, soon became acutely aware ICE continued to operate in ways that did

COLLINS, Page A6



PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Protesters rallied outside the ICE facility in Scarborough, Maine, on Tuesday, a day after an agent killed a man in Biddeford.

Hope-filled journey for a better future cut short

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio, Sabrina Shankman, and Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

BIDDEFORD, Maine — He dreamed of a prosperous future. A robust education for his young daughter. Opportunities he hoped to find in America.

Johan Sebastián Durán Guerrero left behind his native Colombia and settled in southern Maine. He was building a new life here, working multiple jobs, watching his daughter grow up.

On Monday morning, he was shot and killed by an ICE agent outside his family's Biddeford apartment.

It was the second recent deadly shooting by US immigration agents after another man was killed in Texas last week, sparking



"He had a lot of visions to get ahead in life, a lot of dreams to achieve," Omar Durán said of his son, Johan Sebastián Durán Guerrero.

For more than three decades, she has kept Sail Boston afloat

Once more, Rhodes at the helm of this maritime wonder

By Shirley Leung
GLOBE STAFF

A decades-long tradition began as so many good Boston tales do: at a Christmas party at Anthony's Pier 4.

It was the late 1980s, and then-Massport executive director Dave Davis heard rumblings about a regatta being planned for 1992 to mark the quincentenary of Christopher Columbus's voyage to America. Davis turned to Dusty Rhodes and asked if she could help Boston get in on it.

It wouldn't be the first time tall ships sailed into Boston Harbor; they'd come as part of the 1976 bicentennial festivities. But this time Rhodes, who founded the events-planning business Conventures, was on her own, and the nautical world was new to her.

It was perhaps by sheer will that Rhodes got that first Sail Boston off the ground in 1992 — and not without a scandal and a power

RHODES, Page A10



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Massport first turned to Dusty Rhodes for the tall ship extravaganza in 1992. She has since made the nautical event her own.

Home care clinicians for Mass General Brigham planned to return to work following their seven-day strike. **B5.**

The US restored its military blockade on Iran after it targeted ships in the Strait of Hormuz. **A3.**

Serving of steamers

Wednesday: Hot, late storm. High 93-98, low 70-75.

Thursday: Still hot, sunny. High 90-95, low 67-72.

Sunrise: 5:21. Sunset: 8:19.
Comics and weather, **G6-7.**
Obituaries, **C9.**

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